FREE ADULT WELLBEING GUIDE

Stress, Burnout or Something More?

A self-check and reset guide for busy adults

Spot the signs early, use quick reset tools, and know when to ask for help.

eMbrace Lives

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START HERE

Stress, burnout or something more?

Feeling tired, flat and permanently "on" is not a personal failing. In long work weeks, constant notifications and little recovery time, many adults slide from ordinary stress into burnout without noticing. This guide helps you tell the difference and take action.

Not a diagnosis

This guide is a self-reflection tool, not a clinical diagnosis. If your symptoms are severe or persistent, please speak to a mental health professional.

Stress, burnout, anxiety and depression compared

	Stress	Burnout	Anxiety	Depression
Core feeling	Overloaded, too much pressure	Drained, detached, "what's the point at work"	Persistent worry and fear	Persistent low mood, loss of interest
Energy	Wired, tense, still pushing	Depleted, running on empty	Restless or on edge	Heavy and flat
Relief	Often eases when pressure eases	Rest alone often does not fix it	Worry shifts to the next thing	Not tied to one situation
Where it shows	Mostly work or one area	Mostly work, then spreads	Many areas of life	Many areas of life

These overlap, and burnout can lead to anxiety or depression. Burnout is described by the World Health Organization as an occupational phenomenon with three dimensions: exhaustion, mental distance or cynicism about work, and reduced professional efficacy.

SELF-CHECK

How are you really doing?

Tick what has been true most days over the last two weeks.

Body

- [ ] Tired even after a full night's sleep
- [ ] Headaches, tight shoulders or jaw, or stomach trouble
- [ ] Trouble falling or staying asleep
- [ ] Getting ill more often, or slow to recover
- [ ] Changes in appetite

Mind and emotions

- [ ] Dreading the start of the workday
- [ ] Feeling cynical, detached or numb about work
- [ ] Irritable or snapping at people you care about
- [ ] Struggling to concentrate or make simple decisions
- [ ] Feeling ineffective, whatever you do
- [ ] Constant worry or a sense of being behind

Behaviour and life

- [ ] Working late or checking messages nonstop, but achieving less
- [ ] Withdrawing from friends, family or hobbies
- [ ] Relying more on caffeine, alcohol, scrolling or sweets to cope
- [ ] Putting off personal tasks, health appointments or rest
- [ ] No time or energy for things you used to enjoy

READING YOUR RESULTS

What your ticks might mean

Ticks	What it may suggest	What to do
0–6	Everyday stress or a heavy patch	Use the reset tools in this guide and build recovery into your week.
7–12	Early burnout or sustained stress	Make changes now: workload conversation, boundaries, and consider speaking to a counsellor.
13+	Significant burnout, anxiety or low mood is likely	Please speak with a mental health professional. You do not have to wait until it gets worse.

A screening aid, not a test. If you feel hopeless, or have thoughts of harming yourself, skip ahead to the "When to get help" page now.

The slide from stress to burnout

Stage 1: Pushing through

Energy and enthusiasm, working long hours, ignoring small signals.

Stage 2: Running hot

Sleep disrupted, irritability, brain fog, less patience, more caffeine.

Stage 3: Running on empty

Exhaustion, cynicism, withdrawal. Rest does not feel like enough.

Why it creeps up

In always-on work culture, signals are easy to ignore because "everyone is tired." The trick is to notice patterns early and treat recovery as part of the job, not a reward after it.

IMMEDIATE RELIEF

Quick reset tools you can use today

Slow breathing (2 minutes)

Breathe in for 4, out for 6. Repeat for two minutes. The longer out-breath helps calm the body's stress response.

5-4-3-2-1 grounding

Name 5 things you see, 4 you feel, 3 you hear, 2 you smell, 1 you taste. Brings you back to the present.

Brain dump

Write everything on your mind for five minutes, then circle the three that actually matter today.

Micro-breaks

Stand, stretch, look out of a window for two minutes every hour. Eyes and shoulders first.

The 10-minute walk

A short walk after lunch lifts mood and focus. Phone away if you can.

A clear shutdown

End each day with a small ritual: write tomorrow's top three, close the laptop, say "done."

Boundaries that are easy to say

Situation	Try saying
Late-evening message	"Thanks. I'll pick this up first thing tomorrow morning."
Too much on your plate	"I can do A or B by Friday. Which is the priority?"
Weekend request	"I'm offline this weekend. If it's urgent, please call."
Meeting overload	"Could we cover this in a short note instead, so I can protect focus time?"

BUILDING RECOVERY

The foundations that actually move the needle

Sleep
Keep a regular sleep and wake time. Avoid screens for the last hour. A short wind-down routine tells your brain it is safe to switch off.

Movement
Aim for movement most days, even 20 minutes. It is one of the best-supported ways to lift mood and ease anxiety.

Connection
Protect time with people who make you feel like yourself. One honest conversation can lower the load.

Workload
Have a clear conversation about priorities. Make the invisible work visible, with specifics.

Joy and meaning
Schedule one thing weekly that has no productivity value: music, sport, cooking, play.

Support
Talking to a therapist is a skill-building step, not a sign of weakness. Earlier is easier.

Your weekly reset plan

Area	One small change I will make this week	When	Done?

GET SUPPORT

When to get help

Reaching out earlier is almost always easier than waiting for things to get worse. Consider speaking to a professional if:

- You have felt low, anxious or numb for more than two weeks.
- Sleep, appetite or concentration have noticeably changed.
- Panic, racing thoughts or dread are interfering with daily life.
- You are relying on alcohol, substances or overwork to cope.
- Burnout is affecting your relationships, health or ability to function.

If you ever feel unsafe or hopeless

If you are thinking about harming yourself, please contact a helpline or go to the nearest hospital right away. eMbrace is not a crisis service. 24/7 helplines in India include Snehi (+91 9582208181), AASRA (+91 22 27546669) and Vandrevala Foundation (1860 266 2345). Tell someone you trust, too.

How therapy can help

- A confidential space to untangle what is going on, without judgement.
- Evidence-based approaches such as CBT to manage stress, worry and unhelpful thinking.
- Practical tools for boundaries, workload and recovery that fit your real life.
- Where needed, a pathway to a psychiatrist for further evaluation.

Leading a team or HR? eMbrace also supports workplaces with wellbeing programmes and workshops. See embracelives.com/corporate-wellness/corporates.

NEXT STEP

Take the next step with eMbrace

You do not have to power through alone.

If your results suggest it is time to talk, a first consultation is a good, low-pressure step. Our psychologists offer confidential, evidence-based support for stress, burnout, anxiety and low mood, in person or online.

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Support hours	Monday to Saturday, 10 AM to 6 PM IST
Adult stress	embracelives.com/adult-mental-health/stress-management
Burnout	embracelives.com/adult-mental-health/burnout-counselling
Free stress check	embracelives.com/resources/adult-stress-check

Important information

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